carrier, *Fujian*, is heading for multiple sea voyages and is scheduled to join the PLA-N in early 2024. China commissioned its first aircraft carrier, *Liaoning*, in 2012; the second carrier, *Shandong*, commissioned in 2019, is the first Chinese-made carrier.

Commodore Harke points out that with all powerful navies investing in aircraft carriers, their significance is self-explanatory. Naval warfare is complex, he adds, and it's a gross misconception that a carrier is a sitting duck. The mobility, range and flexibility a carrier, along with its escort ships, provides is "unmatched", he says. "*Vikrant*'s power-packed punch can threaten any enemy," the CO adds. "A modern aircraft carrier like *Vikrant* has to take on any incoming challenge independently and collectively when we operate as a carrier battle group. This operational group wields great power and potential to bring an unmatched combat potential."

DEMAND FOR A THIRD CARRIER

The navy has strongly expressed its demand for a third carrier, stating that having an active carrier on each coastline, while another undergoes repairs and refitting (a time-consuming process, often taking over a year) is an absolute necessity for India's maritime security and its new strategic goals. However, former Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Bipin Rawat had openly questioned the enormous expense involved in having a third carrier. The Indian Air Force, too, opposed a third carrier, arguing it can provide air support more effectively from IAF bases. In December 2021, the parliamentary standing committee on defence told the government that three carriers would significantly increase the navy's combat capability. In the same report, however, it suggested the upgradation (building infrastructure, extending runways, etc.) of India's island territories as the Andaman and Nicobar islands as "provisional aircraft carriers".

While it is known that India is actively upgrading its island bases, a final decision on the third carrier is awaited. It is, however, very much on the table.

"Our policy planners always had the vision to have a blue water navy, with its effective presence in the Indian Ocean Region. We had thought of a three carrier navy since then. A carrier force gives a punch to operations, it can go anywhere," says Commodore Harke. Military planners the world over agree. The US Navy, for example, has increased its reliance on the flat-top, deploying CBGs (carrier battle groups) to the Mediterranean sea, and the Pacific, Indian and the North Atlantic oceans, patrolling their waters at will. Indeed, the role of British aircraft carriers HMS *Hermes* and *Invincible* in the Falklands War, fought thousands of miles from their home bases, cannot be exaggerated. Planners maintain that the carrier is the only platform that provides comprehensive access to littoral (areas lying along a shore) spaces. Thus, the navy's steadfast demand for a third carrier is in tune with India's planned power projection in the Indo-Pacific region.

THE NAVY'S DEMAND FOR A THIRD CARRIER IS IN TUNE WITH INDIA'S PLANNED POWER-PROJECTION IN THE INDO-PACIFIC REGION

The Cochin Shipyard is confident about making a third aircraft carrier at a much faster pace. "If the platform is largely derived from what the CSL has done now, with functional upgrades and latest technological trends, we are confident to deliver the sister ship of the same class in the next seven to eight years. And, with targeting an 85 per cent indigenous content," Nair says.

A majority of *Vikrant*'s systems have been successfully tested in its sea trials, and after commissioning, the integration trials of its fixed-wing aircraft would continue. The *Vikrant* already has an aircraft and helicopter on board. Flying trials in a new carrier can take close to two years before it is operationally deployed. Without dwelling on a timeline, Commodore Harke says that the UK carrier HMS *Queen Elizabeth* took two years for its first operational deployment after its commissioning. Even the US Navy, which operates the highest number of carriers (11), takes time for full deployment of its prize assets.

At the moment, the navy has plans to operationalise the warship's combat potential with MiGs. Naval authorities are in the process of finalising the acquisition of fighter jets to operate from the carrier in future. The Dassault Rafale-M (French) and Boeing F/A-18 Super Hornet (US) are considered to be the main contenders. The navy is expected to get 26 such fighter jets through an intergovernmental agreement. India's Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA) is also building a twin-engine, deck-based fighter for carriers. The first test flight is expected by 2026 and induction by 2031.

Once operational, *Vikrant* will be deployed in Visakhapatnam, a formidable sentinel on the eastern sea bed. India's other aircraft carrier, INS *Vikramaditya*, is based in Karwar, Karnataka, on India's western seafront. ■